



DESIGNING FOR DISCOVERY

Designing structured content systems that
support discoverability

Holly Melone

Contents

Why discovery matters.....	4
Foundation for discoverability.....	4
Information architecture.....	5
Designing the skeleton of discoverable content	5
Why IA matters for discovery	6
From chaos to clarity.....	6
Core components of information architecture	7
How to build IA that supports discovery	8
Designing IA through card sorting	9
Validate navigation with tree testing.....	10
From system structure to structured content	11
Content models.....	12
The blueprint for content structure.....	12
How to create content models.....	12
Designing content models for usability.....	15
Common pitfalls in content modeling	16
From structured content to discoverable content	16
Metadata.....	17
Types of metadata.....	17
Designing effective metadata	19
Metadata in practice.....	20
From structure to sustainability	20
Sustaining the system: governance and analytics.....	21
Maintaining discovery	21
Governance.....	21
Analytics	21
A continuous lifecycle	22
More resources	23
Discoverability checklist	23

Tools for designing discoverable content	24
Research and validation tools.....	24
Content modeling and structure	25
Structured content and machine-readable data	26
References and further reading	27

Why discovery matters

Discovery determines whether valuable information is used or ignored. It affects user experience, trust, and the efficiency of teams and organizations.

When people and systems can find and understand information easily, content becomes a reliable resource that supports efficiency and scale. When they cannot, even high-quality content goes unused, regardless of its worth. This leads to frustration, repeated questions, and increased reliance on subject matter experts (SMEs) and support teams.

In many documentation systems, content is difficult to find, not because it's missing, but because it is poorly organized, inconsistently labeled, or disconnected from how users search. As content grows, these issues compound, making navigation confusing, search unreliable, and maintenance difficult.

Foundation for discoverability

Designing for discoverability starts with creating clear structure, consistent organization, and meaningful metadata so information can be easily found and used.

This guide focuses on the following three core components of that system:

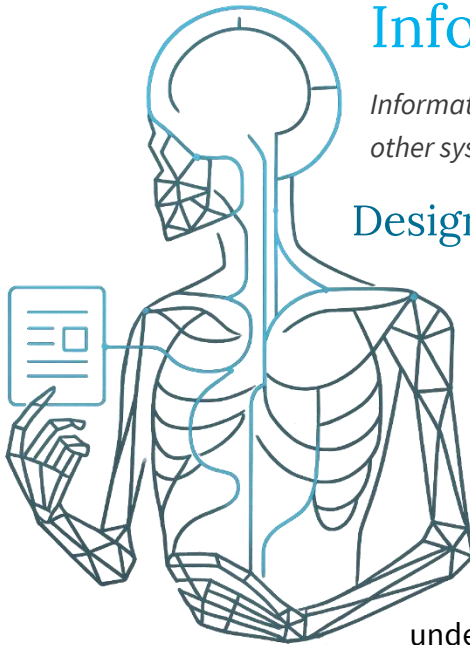
Discipline	Core focus	Elements supporting discoverability	Outcome
Information architecture	Organizes content across a system	Structure, hierarchy, navigation	Helps users browse and locate content
Content modeling	Structures individual content types	Content types, fields, consistency	Ensures content is predictable and scalable
Metadata	Describes content for retrieval	Tags, attributes, relationships	Enables search, filtering, and connections

Together, these elements form the foundation of a discoverable content system. When they are aligned, content becomes easier to find, easier to maintain, and more scalable over time.

Information architecture

Information architecture gives discovery its skeleton. It's the structure that every other system builds upon.

Designing the skeleton of discoverable content



Information architecture (IA) defines how content is organized and navigated within a system. It shapes how information is grouped, labeled, and connected so users can understand where content lives and how to move through it.

More broadly, IA is the structural design of shared information environments and the coordination of organization, labeling, search, and navigation systems to support findability and understanding (Rosenfeld, Morville, and Arango 2015).

Information architecture is often described in multiple ways, but at its core it defines how content is organized and navigated within a system.

Whether you are organizing an existing site or designing a new one, IA begins with the same goal: creating a structure that reflects how users think, search, and complete tasks. This structure is built on clear hierarchy, consistent labeling, and meaningful relationships between content.

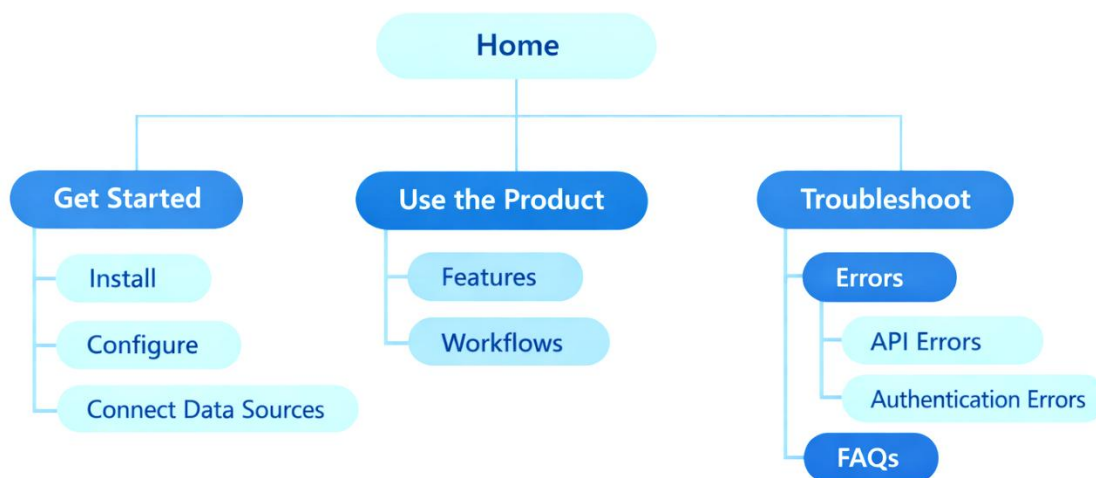


Figure 1: An example of information architecture. Content is organized into a clear hierarchy with task-based grouping and connections between related topics.

Why IA matters for discovery

Good IA structure does more than organize information. It determines how content is found and trusted. When information has a clear hierarchy and consistent labels, users can find what they need without guessing, backtracking, or retrying searches.

This structure improves both internal search and SEO by making relationships between content clearer and more consistent. It also helps AI and other systems interpret how content is organized, which supports more accurate retrieval and recommendations.

Weak IA fragments content and breaks the connections that keep it coherent. Users bounce between sections, navigation becomes inconsistent, and related content is harder to locate. Even well-written content becomes difficult to use when the structure beneath it breaks down.

From chaos to clarity

Without intentional design, documentation systems often grow organically. Teams add content over time using inconsistent structures, labels, and categories. As a result, navigation becomes fragmented and users are forced to guess where information lives.

These problems often stem from internal thinking rather than user needs. Content is shaped by:

- Internal terminology
- Product-centric organization
- Legacy structures
- Assumptions about how information should be grouped

In the diagram to the right, the “before” view, content is scattered across legacy folders and overlapping categories with no clear hierarchy. Navigation loops back on itself, making discovery slow and frustrating.

The “after” view shows a structure organized around user intent. Content is grouped by task or goal, such as Install, Configure, and Troubleshoot. Each category acts as a clear entry point, reducing cognitive load and making related content easier to find.

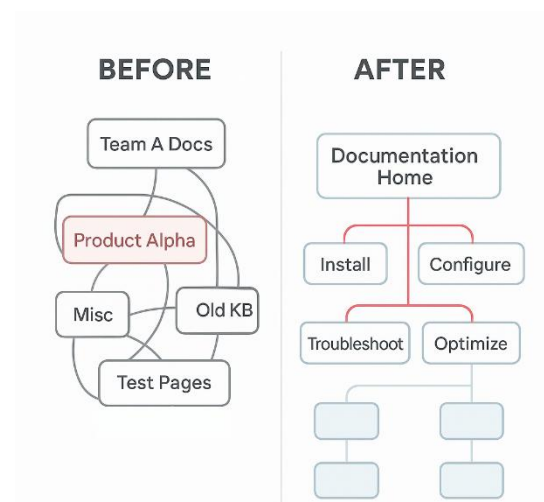


Figure 2: Clear structure transforms discovery. On the left, users must navigate ad hoc links and disconnected pages. On the right, a defined hierarchy organizes content by task (Install, Configure, Troubleshoot, Optimize) creating predictable paths that make information easier to find and maintain.

When architecture reflects how users think rather than internal assumptions, navigation becomes more predictable and content easier to maintain.

Core components of information architecture

A strong IA balances clarity with flexibility. The following components shape how content is organized and navigated:

- **Hierarchy** defines the structure of content from broad categories to specific topics. Organizing content from general to specific helps users understand where they are and how to move deeper into a system.
- **Navigation** provides pathways through content. Menus, breadcrumbs, and internal links allow users to move between related topics and reach their goals from multiple entry points.
- **Taxonomy** organizes content into structured categories. Consistent, task-based groupings such as “Install,” “Configure,” and “Integrations” help users understand how topics relate to each other.
- **Labeling** defines how content is presented in words. Clear, user-focused labels based on search behavior and feedback improve understanding and reduce friction.
- **Internal linking** connects related content. Predictable linking patterns reinforce structure and help users discover relevant information without relying on search.

When these components are aligned, users can navigate content confidently and find what they need with less effort.

How to build IA that supports discovery

IA is not a static deliverable. It is a design process that improves through research, testing, and iteration. Content professionals can strengthen structure by treating it as a user-facing system that evolves with feedback and needs.

1. **Audit what exists, map what users need.**

- If you're designing a content system from the start, begin by listing key goals and questions your audience will bring, then design categories and navigation around those.
- For existing content systems, do a content inventory to identify overlaps, gaps, and confusing pathways. This helps reveal whether your hierarchy matches user intent or internal assumptions.



Starting your IA from scratch? Follow these steps.

1. Identify user goals and top tasks.
2. Sketch a draft hierarchy on paper or whiteboard.
3. Label categories in your users' language.
4. Validate with quick user testing before scaling.

2. **Define clear groupings.**

Cluster related topics into logical categories that reflect how users complete tasks, not internal terminology or product-centric organization.

3. **Label for intent.**

Use the language your users search for. Content labels should reflect audience vocabulary, not internal terminology.

4. **Connect through taxonomy.**

Use structured categories and controlled vocabularies to group related topics consistently. Taxonomy defines high-level categories such as “Install,” “Integrate,” and “Troubleshoot” that shape navigation and help users understand how topics relate.

5. **Add context with metadata.**

Apply descriptive metadata such as summaries, audience, product/version, and tags to clarify what each page is about and improve search and filtering.

6. Test and refine.

Use analytics, feedback, and usability testing to identify where users hesitate or fail to find what they need. Adjust navigation and taxonomy as you go.



How deep should your hierarchy go?

Forget the old “three-click rule.” What matters isn’t the number of steps, it’s how clear and logical they feel.

- Go deep enough to show meaningful relationships, but not so deep that users lose orientation. Each step should confirm progress toward the right information.
- Use analytics and user testing to evaluate where people hesitate or backtrack; that’s where your structure needs refinement.

The goal is to create *just enough depth to support meaning without hiding it.*

freely between people, AI tools, and systems.

Designing IA through card sorting

Once a basic content structure is in place, it helps to test whether users actually interpret it the way you expect. Card sorting is one of the simplest ways to do this. In a card sort, users group related topics together and label those groups in a way that feels natural to them. This reveals how people think about your content, showing the mental model that guides their navigation and search behavior.

You can run a quick version with sticky notes, a whiteboard, or a digital tool such as Miro or FigJam.

1. List 20–30 representative topics from your site or documentation set.
2. Invite participants to group the topics and discuss their reasoning.
3. Patterns will emerge: some labels will be confusing, some groupings unexpected. These insights help refine your hierarchy and taxonomy before redesigning or migrating content.

Card sorting turns IA into a conversation with your audience. It shifts structure from assumption to evidence, showing where users' expectations align or diverge from the original design.

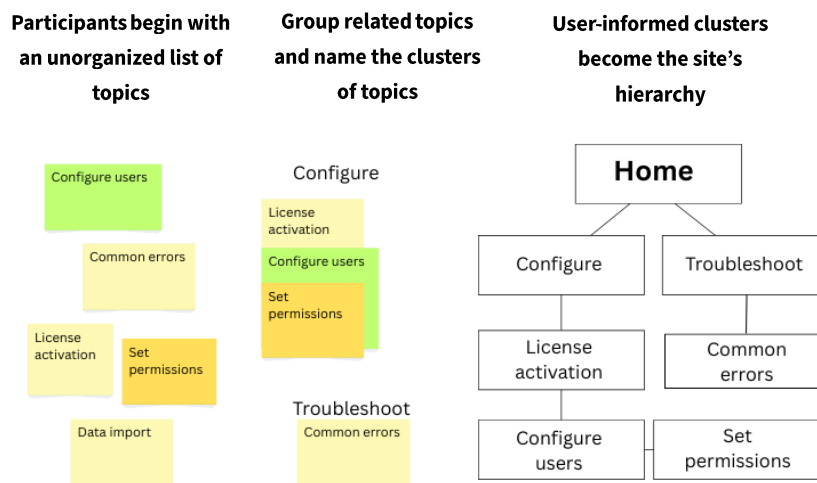


Figure 3: Card sorting to design structure. Card sorting transforms raw topics into patterns that mirror user thinking. Writers begin with unorganized content, users group it by task or goal, and those clusters evolve into the site's final hierarchy. The result is a structure shaped by user logic instead of internal assumptions.

Validate navigation with tree testing

Tree testing confirms whether users can find information using only your raw structure, without interface elements, visual cues, or search. It's one of the fastest ways to validate naming, grouping, and hierarchy before committing to a design.

Here's how to run an effective tree test:

- 1. Prepare a simplified "tree."**

Export your proposed hierarchy as a text list (category → subcategory → pages). Keep it clean and label-free except for the terms you're testing.

- 2. Choose 5–10 real tasks.**

Use real search logs or support cases to create tasks such as "Where would you go to configure API authentication?" or "Find steps for upgrading to version 7.4."

- 3. Recruit a small sample (6–10 users).**

They can be support engineers, customer success teammates, or internal SMEs who resemble your audience. Tree testing works even with tiny groups.

4. **Run the test using a simple tool.**

Tools like Optimal Workshop, Maze, or even a Google Form work:

- Present one task at a time
- Ask the user to click through the tree until they choose a destination
- Capture the path they took, time to complete, and confidence level

5. **Analyze the patterns.**

Look for:

- High failure paths (users consistently choose the wrong branch)
- Hesitation points (long pauses before selecting a label)
- Label ambiguity (users split across multiple categories)
- Hidden content (deep nesting that prevents discovery)

6. **Refine labels and groupings.**

Update your taxonomy, labels, and hierarchy based on user behavior — not team assumptions.

Tree testing gives you evidence about whether your IA matches how people naturally think, helping you refine structure based on real user behavior.

From system structure to structured content

Information architecture defines how content is organized and navigated across a system. Once that structure is in place, the next step is ensuring that individual pieces of content are structured consistently and can scale as the system grows.

This is the role of **content modeling**.

Content models

Content modeling defines how individual pieces of content are structured, ensuring consistency, scalability, and reuse across a system.

The blueprint for content structure

A content model is the big-picture map of all your content types and how they relate. It defines *what kinds* of content exist (like knowledge articles, tutorials, and release notes) and how they connect (an article links to a product, a release note to a version). Content models are defined templates used by writers, designers, and developers to ensure consistent content structures.

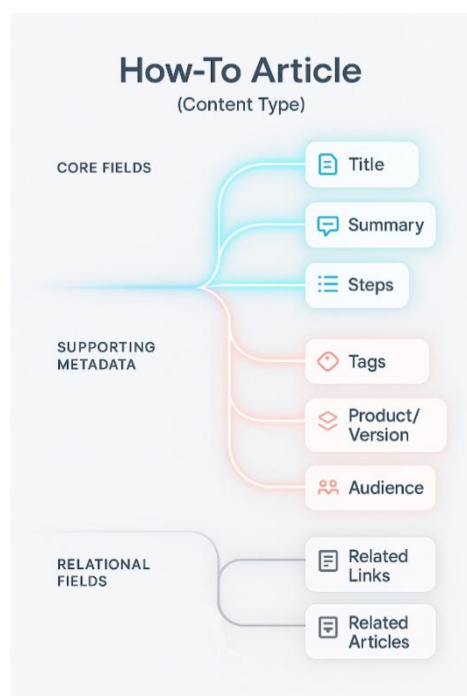


Figure 4: Blueprint for Structure

A content model defines the structure writers follow before content is published. By standardizing fields and relationships, it ensures that every piece of content carries the same

- Content models ensure consistency and reduce ambiguity by defining which elements belong in each content type.
- They guide contributors by clarifying purpose, required fields, and how each type should be used.
- They provide a predictable framework that supports structured authoring and makes content scalable across teams and tools.

How to create content models

Creating a content model means defining the structure, relationships, and rules for each type of content in your ecosystem. It's both a strategic design process and a collaboration exercise across teams.

1. Identify your core content types

Start by listing the distinct kinds of content your organization produces. For example, *How-To Article*, *Release Note*, *Product Overview*, or *API Reference*. Each of these will become a separate content type.

2. Define each content type's purpose

For each type, describe what it's meant to achieve and how users will interact with it.

Example:

- A How-To Article uses elements like steps, summaries, and related links to guide users through completing a task.
- An API Reference includes fields such as parameters, request and response examples, and error codes to support precise technical lookup.

3. List required fields and elements

Specify what every instance of that content type must include.

Example fields: *Title, Summary, Steps, Version, Product, Related Links, Tags.*

These become the building blocks of consistency, helping writers and systems know what to expect.

Content Model: How-To Article

Title

Summary

Prerequisites

- Required setup steps
- Necessary tools

Steps

1. Step one
2. Step two
3. Step three

Expected Outcome

Related Articles

- Link to related topic
- Additional resources

Product: WidgetPro Version: 2.3 Tags: Troubleshooting, Tutorial

Tags: Troubleshooting Tutorial Add Tag +

Figure 5: A simple content model. The example above shows how a content model defines structure for a common documentation type. Each field serves a purpose. Steps guide action, summaries provide quick context, and metadata fields support search, filtering, and relationships. Together, they create a predictable structure that both users and systems can rely on.

4. **Define relationships between content types**

Identify how content types should connect to each other and document those relationships explicitly.

Start by asking:

- What content does a user need before this?
- What content should come next?
- What related topics should be surfaced alongside it?

Then define those relationships in your model. For example:

- A product includes related features
- A feature links to how-to and troubleshooting articles
- A how-to article references prerequisites and related tasks
- A troubleshooting article connects back to the feature

5. **Document metadata requirements**

Define the metadata your system will use and how each field should be created, applied, and maintained. Start by identifying which attributes help users and machines understand, classify, and retrieve content (such as audience, lifecycle stage, or product area). Then document how each field is populated and when it should be updated.

6. **Prototype and validate**

Test your model with real examples. Can authors use it easily? Does it produce consistent results? Iterate based on author and user feedback.

7. **Implement in your CMS or authoring environment**

Once validated, configure your CMS to enforce the model structure – fields, templates, and relationships.

8. **Maintain version control and governance**

Content models evolve as products, audiences, and technology change. Assign



Linking related content

Relationships between content should be implemented through structured fields such as “Related content” or “See also,” not added manually by authors. Defining these fields in the content model ensures relationships are applied consistently across the system.

For example, you might limit related content to articles within the same product or feature and restrict the number of links shown. This keeps relationships relevant, consistent, and scalable.

ownership and review cycles to keep them relevant and aligned with taxonomy and schema updates.

Designing content models for usability

Content models should not only enforce structure but also support how people read, understand, and use information. A well-designed model reflects user needs, not just system requirements.

- **Start with user goals**
Define content types based on what users are trying to accomplish, not how your organization is structured. Use search logs, support tickets, and user feedback to identify common tasks and questions.
- **Design for clarity and readability**
Structure fields to support scannable content. Use clear headings, concise summaries, and logical sequencing so users can quickly evaluate and apply information.
- **Ensure consistency across content types**
Consistent patterns help users recognize how content is organized. When layouts and fields behave predictably, users can focus on the information rather than the format.
- **Prototype and test early**
Validate content models with real examples. Test whether authors can use them easily and whether users can navigate and understand the resulting content.
- **Iterate based on feedback**
Use analytics and user feedback to refine content models over time. Adjust fields, relationships, and structures to better support evolving user needs.

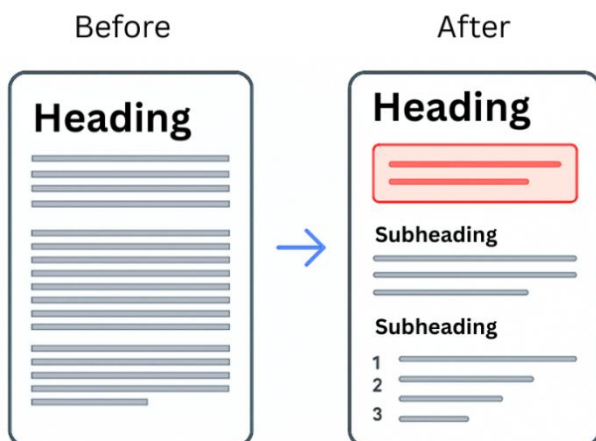


Figure 6: Designing content for usability, accessibility, and discovery

Clear, accessible structure helps users understand information quickly, creating better usability and stronger discovery. Use meaningful headings, short paragraphs, and well-organized lists to make content easy to scan and apply.

Common pitfalls in content modeling

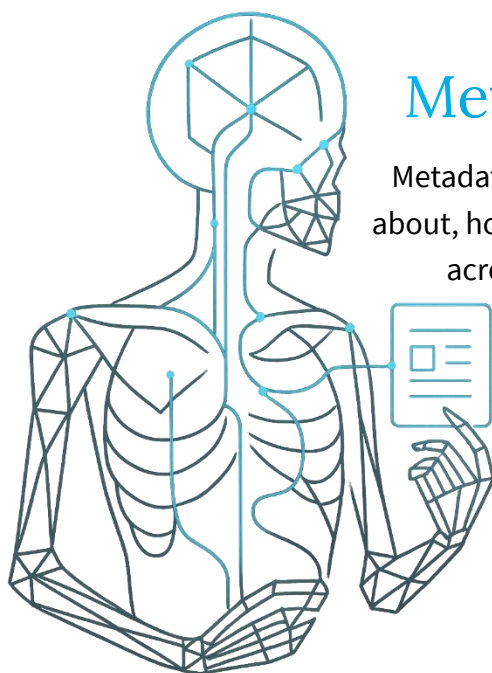
Content models often fail when they are designed for systems instead of people. Findability depends on both how information is structured and how users seek it, reinforcing the need to align systems with real user behavior (Morville 2005).

- **Too many fields**
Overly complex models slow down authors and lead to inconsistent use.
- **Unclear field purpose**
If contributors don't understand when or how to use a field, it becomes unreliable.
- **Inconsistent application**
Without governance, the same content type can be structured differently across teams.
- **Ignoring user needs**
Models based on internal logic rather than user tasks lead to content that is technically correct but hard to use.

From structured content to discoverable content

Content models define the fields that structure content, creating consistency across a system. Once that structure is in place, the next step is making that content discoverable.

This is the role of **metadata**. Metadata populates those fields with meaningful values that make content searchable, filterable, and connected. It adds descriptive context to content, helping systems understand what it is about, how it relates to other content, and when it should be surfaced. It enables search, filtering, and intelligent retrieval, allowing both people and systems to find the right information at the right time.



Metadata

Metadata provides the descriptive context that defines what content is about, how it should be categorized, and how it relates to other content across a system.

While content modeling defines the structure of content, metadata fills in that structure with meaningful values. Fields such as product, version, audience, and tags allow content to be organized dynamically rather than fixed in a single location.

This flexibility is what makes modern content systems powerful. Metadata enables content to be filtered, reused, personalized, and surfaced in multiple contexts without being rewritten or duplicated. It allows the same content to support different users, workflows, and interfaces, from search results to support tools to AI-driven experiences.

Types of metadata

Metadata can be grouped into a few practical categories based on how it supports discovery and system behavior.

Descriptive metadata

Describes what the content is about.

- Summary
- Topic
- Keywords or tags
- Title (used for indexing and display)

Helps users and systems quickly understand the subject and purpose of content.



When to surface metadata as labels

Content models define fields such as product, version, or content type. The values in those fields are metadata.

Some metadata can be surfaced as visible labels when it helps users understand what they're viewing. For example, displaying product name, version, or content type provides useful context.

Only surface metadata when it adds clear value to the user experience.

Structural metadata

Defines how content is organized and related.

- Content type (How-to, FAQ, Release note)
- Relationships (related articles, parent/child topics)
- Section or category

Connects content across a system and supports navigation and reuse.

Administrative metadata

Provides context for management and maintenance.

- Author or owner
- Created and updated dates
- Version
- Lifecycle status (draft, published, archived)

Supports governance, version control, and content lifecycle management.

Contextual (or business) metadata

Aligns content to products, users, or use cases.

- Product
- Feature
- Audience (admin, end user, developer)
- Environment or platform

Enables filtering, personalization, and delivery of the right content to the right audience.

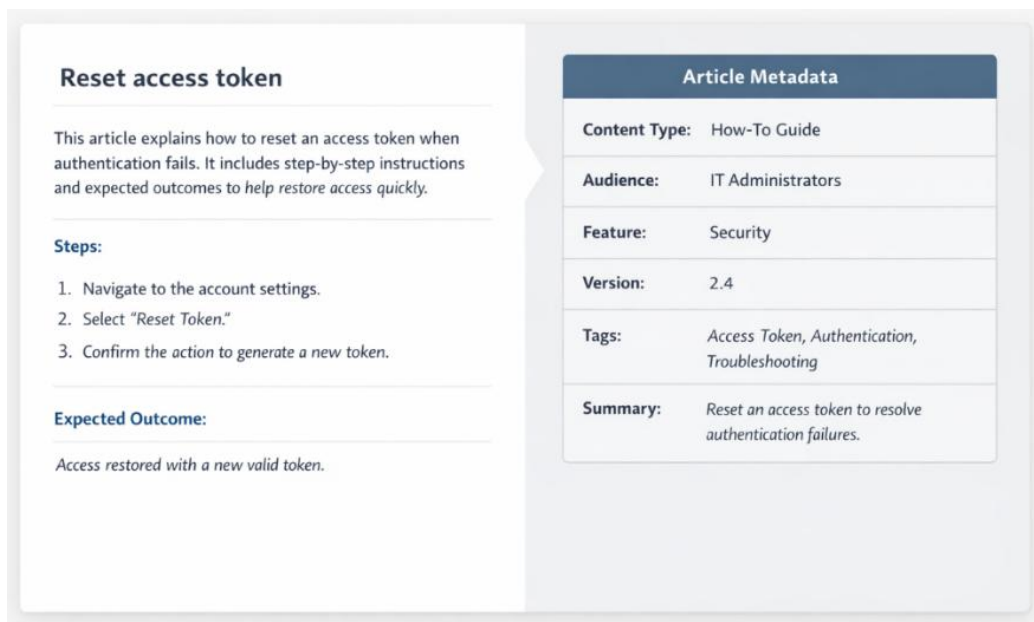


Figure 7: Example of metadata applied to an article. Metadata fields provide structured context that helps systems organize, connect, and surface content across different use cases.

Without metadata, a how-to article exists in one location and must be found manually. With metadata (product, feature, version), the same article can surface dynamically in search, support tools, and AI responses.

Designing effective metadata

Metadata is only useful if it is consistent, intentional, and maintained over time.

- Use controlled vocabularies**
 Define approved values for fields like product, feature, and audience to prevent duplication and inconsistency. Let users select these options rather than free typing them.
- Align metadata with user behavior**
 Base tags and categories on how users search, not internal terminology.
- Keep it minimal but meaningful**
 Too many fields reduce consistency. Focus on the metadata that directly supports discovery and reuse.
- Define clear usage rules**
 Document what each field means and how it should be applied so contributors use it consistently.
- Audit and refine regularly**
 Review metadata usage to identify gaps, duplicates, or outdated values.

Metadata in practice

Metadata makes content dynamically discoverable. When applied consistently, it allows the same content to appear in multiple contexts based on user needs.

It's essential for successful search. Search performance relies on consistent structure and metadata. Without clear fields, labels, and relationships, search systems struggle to return accurate results (Nielsen Norman Group).

In practice, metadata enables:

- **Filtering and faceted navigation**
Users can narrow results by attributes such as product, role, version, or environment, helping them quickly find relevant content without scanning everything.
- **Search relevance and ranking**
Metadata helps search systems prioritize results by matching queries to structured fields such as topic, tags, and product associations.
- **Related content and recommendations**
Shared metadata fields connect content across topics. Articles tagged with the same product, feature, or task can be surfaced together based on shared metadata, reducing reliance on manual linking.
- **Content reuse across systems**
Structured metadata allows content to be reused in multiple interfaces, such as documentation sites, support tools, and in-product help, without duplication.
- **Targeted delivery and personalization**
Metadata can be used to tailor content based on user role, context, or environment, ensuring that users see information that is relevant to their situation.
- **Reporting and performance insights**
Metadata enables teams to analyze content performance across dimensions such as product, feature, audience, or content type. This makes it possible to identify gaps, track usage trends, and prioritize updates based on real data.

From structure to sustainability

To keep meaning consistent and systems responsive, discovery needs maintenance as much as design. **Governance** and **analytics** sustain that continuity, ensuring that your structures remain accurate, usable, and adaptive as technologies evolve.

Sustaining the system: governance and analytics

Maintaining discovery

For discovery to thrive, it requires maintenance as much as design. Once structure, modeling, and metadata are in place, governance and analytics ensure the system remains consistent as it evolves.

Although this guide focuses on design rather than long-term management, governance and analytics are essential. They close the loop between design intent and lived experience, ensuring that discovery remains accurate, relevant, and adaptable as the ecosystem grows.

Governance

Governance defines how content decisions are made, maintained, and measured over time. It establishes clear ownership, lifecycle rules, and review processes so that taxonomy, metadata, relationships, and publishing workflows remain consistent and accountable.

Governance is not about control. It creates clarity, accountability, and consistency over time. It ensures that the structures supporting discovery continue to work as intended as content, tools, and teams evolve. Effective governance creates shared standards, assigns responsibility, and provides mechanisms for feedback, ensuring that meaning stays stable even as information changes.

Content governance requires ongoing oversight, clear processes, and sustained resources. Without it, teams revert to inconsistent practices over time, reducing the effectiveness of the content system (Rockley and Cooper 2012).

Analytics

Analytics reveal how discovery performs in practice. They show how users search, what they select, and where they struggle.



Getting started with governance and analytics

To begin:

1. Identify content owners.
2. Define update cadence (such as quarterly or release-based).
3. Set metrics for discoverability (such as search success, duplicate reduction, time to answer).
4. Use analytics to prioritize improvements.

Helpful signals include:

- Search queries and zero-result searches
- Click paths and navigation behavior
- Time to find information
- Repeated support questions or failed tasks

These signals highlight gaps in structure, unclear labels, or missing relationships. Used well, analytics create a feedback loop that informs improvements to IA, content models, and metadata.

Together, governance and analytics sustain the system. They turn discovery from a one-time project into a continuous process of learning and refinement.

A continuous lifecycle

Discovery does not end when content is published. Each stage informs the next:

Plan → Create → Review → Publish → Analyze → Refine → Archive

The content lifecycle reflects the reality that every piece of content is part of something larger, a network of knowledge that grows and adapts. People and machines won't find your content if it's not updated and archived when necessary.

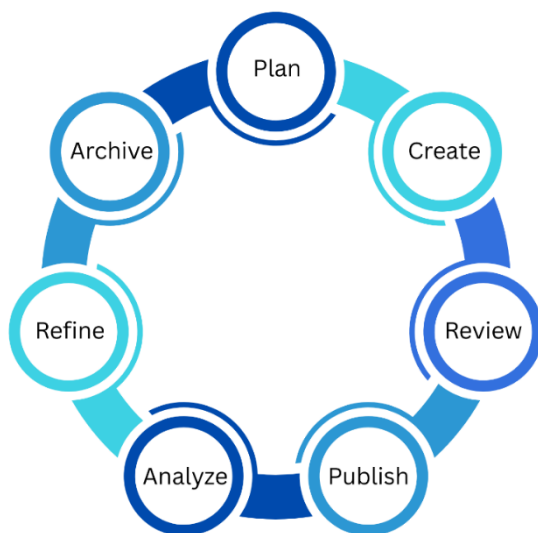


Figure 8: The content lifecycle

This diagram illustrates the ongoing process of maintaining discoverable content. Each stage – Plan, Create, Review, Publish, Analyze, Refine, and Archive – feeds into the next, forming a continuous loop that keeps information accurate, usable, and relevant over time.

More resources

Discoverability checklist

Use this checklist to evaluate whether your content system supports discovery:

Information architecture

- Can a new user complete a common task (for example, “install the product”) without using search?
- Do navigation labels match the terms users search for in analytics or support tickets?
- Are similar topics grouped together, or are they split across different sections or products?
- When viewing one article of content, are there clear links to the next logical step (for example, from setup → configuration → troubleshooting)?

Content modeling

- Do articles of the same type (such as how-to guides) follow the same structure and sections?
- Are required fields (for example, summary, steps, version) consistently present across similar content?
- Can authors easily tell what type of content they are creating and what belongs in it?
- Are relationships between content types defined (for example, feature → related how-to → related troubleshooting)?

Metadata

- Do similar articles use the same tags, or are there duplicates (for example, “API” vs “api” vs “API setup”)?
- Can users filter content by meaningful attributes such as product, role, or version?
- Does metadata reflect how users search, or does it use internal terminology?
- When metadata is missing or incorrect, does it impact search results or filtering?
- Do related articles appear automatically or require manual linking?

Validation and maintenance

- Have you tested navigation using real tasks (card sort or tree test)?
- Can you identify where users fail to find content using analytics or search logs?
- Are outdated or duplicate articles regularly identified and removed?
- Is there a clear owner responsible for maintaining structure, metadata, and content quality?

Tools for designing discoverable content

These tools support different parts of the discovery process, from structuring content to validating whether users can actually find it.

Research and validation tools

Card sorting tools

- Miro
- FigJam
- Optimal Workshop

What they do:

Card sorting helps you understand how users group and label information. Participants organize topics into categories that make sense to them, revealing their mental models.

When to use them:

- Designing or restructuring navigation
- Validating taxonomy and grouping
- Identifying user-friendly labels

Why they matter:

They prevent you from organizing content based on internal assumptions. Instead, structure reflects how users actually think.

Tree testing tools

- Optimal Workshop
- Maze

What they do:

Tree testing evaluates whether users can find information in your structure without relying on UI or design.

When to use them:

- After defining IA
- Before redesign or migration

Why they matter:

They reveal whether your hierarchy and labels actually work in practice—not just in theory.

Content modeling and structure

Content modeling tools

- Airtable
- Notion
- Contentful

What they do:

These tools help you define content types, fields, and relationships before implementing them in a CMS.

When to use them:

- Designing content models
- Documenting fields and templates
- Aligning teams on structure

Why they matter:

They make content structure explicit and reusable, instead of relying on inconsistent author decisions.

Metadata and taxonomy management

Spreadsheet-based tools

- Microsoft Excel
- Google Sheets

What they do:

Used to define and manage taxonomy, tags, and metadata fields.

When to use them:

- Building controlled vocabularies
- Auditing metadata
- Planning migrations

Why they matter:

Most metadata systems start here. They allow you to standardize terms before enforcing them in a CMS.

Structured content and machine-readable data

Schema and structured data tools

- Schema.org

What it does:

Schema.org provides a shared vocabulary for structuring content so that search engines and systems can interpret it consistently.

When to use it:

- Enhancing search visibility (SEO)
- Structuring content for machine interpretation
- Supporting rich results and integrations

References and further reading

Rosenfeld, Louis, Peter Morville, and Jorge Arango. 2015. *Information Architecture for the Web and Beyond*. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly Media.

Rockley, Ann, and Charles Cooper. 2012. *Managing Enterprise Content: A Unified Content Strategy*. 2nd ed. Berkeley, CA: New Riders.

Morville, Peter. 2005. *Ambient Findability*. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly Media.

Nielsen Norman Group. 2022. "Intranet-Search Essentials."

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/intranet-search/>

NISO (National Information Standards Organization). 2004. *Understanding Metadata*. Bethesda, MD: NISO Press.

Schema.org. n.d. "Schema.org." <https://schema.org>